

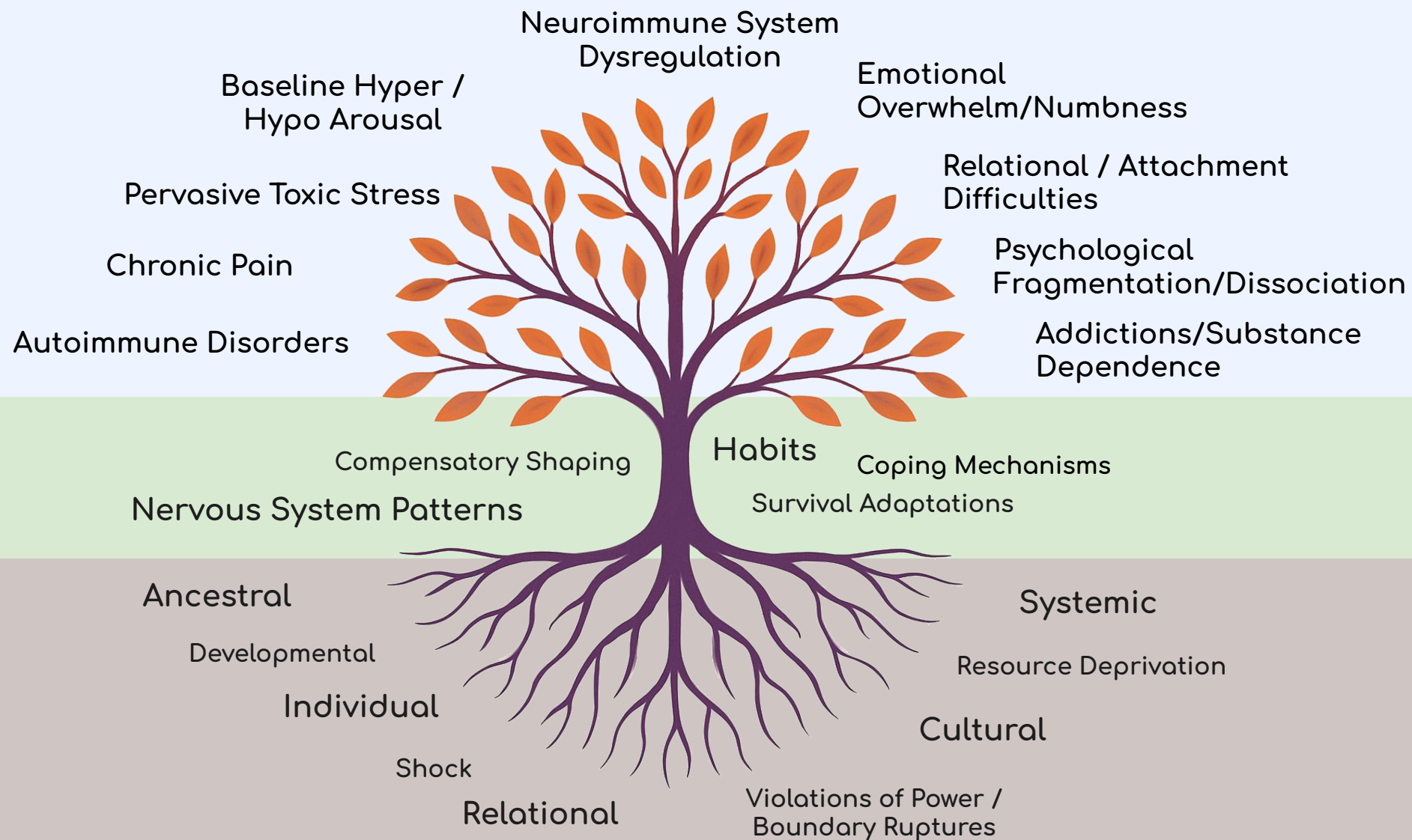
The Pre-Perinatal Continuum: An Overview

with Dr. Scott Lyons, Manuela Mischke-Reeds MFT,
and Dr. Arielle Schwartz

What is Trauma?

- There is too much too soon
- There is too much for too long
- There is not enough for too long
- Power and agency have been taken away from the person or collective
- The stressors outweigh the resources available to navigate them
- When our primal protective instincts, intuitions, and responses are thwarted
- There is not enough time, space, or permission to heal

TRAUMA



Developmental Building Blocks

A**B****C****D****E****F****G****ATTACHMENT****BONDING****CO-REGULATION****DEVELOPMENTAL****EXPLORATION****FEELINGS****GROUNDED**

ATTACHMENT gives us our first sense of safety and love in the world.

BONDING moments teach us that closeness can feel good, comforting, and secure.

Through **CO-REGULATION**, a calm, caring presence helps our bodies and hearts settle.

Our **DEVELOPMENTAL** growth unfolds best when we feel seen, safe, and supported.

With steady care, **EXPLORATION** becomes exciting instead of scary.

We learn to understand and share our **FEELINGS** when others listen with kindness.

Loving connection helps us feel **GROUNDED**, steady, and at home in ourselves.

Healthy attachment and early bonding give us our first experience of safety and connection, teaching our bodies that the world can be trusted. Through loving co-regulation, we learn to settle our nervous system and grow in steady, developmental stages. Supported in this way, exploration becomes joyful, our feelings make sense, and we begin to understand ourselves and others with more ease. Over time, this nurturing foundation helps us stay grounded, even when life becomes challenging.



What Is Developmental Trauma

- Disruption of Core Rhythms and shapes Nervous System Development
- Interruption of Developmental Milestones
- Disrupts emotional regulation capacities
- Fragmentation of early structures of self and relationships
- Lack of opportunities to create the building blocks of security and safety
- Incomplete or Unmet Developmental Needs

Indicators of Developmental Trauma

Somatic Indicators:

- Primal freeze: still, shallow breathing
- Heightened sensitivity to sounds and touch (easily startled)
- Increased pain sensitivity
- Anxiety/panic in confined spaces
- Disorientation or fogginess in somatic experience

Emotional Indicators:

- Themes around not deserving to exist, wanted, unsafe or seen
- Themes around time: chronic lateness or time confusion
- Chronicity of emotions: stuckness/waiting to be rescued, emptiness

Indicators of Developmental Trauma

Relational Indicators:

- Insecure attachment
- Ambivalence for closeness and nurturance
- Difficulty transitioning

Memory Indicators:

- No conscious trauma memory but strong somatic reactions
- Somatic responses to medical environments and bodily invasions

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Prenatal & Perinatal Stage (0-6 months)

Developmental Needs

- Safety in the womb and during birth
- Physiological support through caregiver regulation (nutrition, environment, attunement)
- Being emotionally welcome into life
- A protected entry into life where existence itself feels safe enough

Disruptions & Trauma Patterns

- Primordial/primal freeze: shutdown of brain, body, and developmental sequencing
- Prenatal stressors (maternal abuse, drug/alcohol exposure, lack of medical support, unsafe environment, unwanted pregnancy, high stressors for the mother during conception and pregnancy)
- Birth trauma (complications, C-section impact, invasive medical interventions, incubator time)
- Extended separation, neglect, or postpartum depression in caregiver
- Somatic presentation: frozen core, joint/muscle tension, infant dissociation, dysregulated nervous system, interrupted development, global mistrust

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Prenatal & Perinatal Stage (0-6 months) continued...

Core Needs & Negative Cognitions

- Core need: It is safe for me to exist & I am welcome here, it's safe to be embodied
- Common NCs: "I shouldn't exist," "I am not wanted," "I cannot trust the world," "I do not belong," "my body is not safe."

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Infancy & Dependence Stage (6 months-1.5 years)

Developmental Needs

- Safety & Security: protection, rest, reliable holding, consistent caregiving
- Connection: love, belonging, attachment, early communication, sense of - primary attachment
- Being tended to in a timely way when needs arise
- Validation & Empathy: being seen and felt, - foundational development of the self.
- Mirrored Play: spontaneous expression, joyful engagement, rhythm and co-regulation through play
- Agency: choosing and signaling needs
- Safety (Theme): establishing the body's baseline trust in protection and care in relation to the primary caregivers
- Emotional Regulation: co-regulation scaffolds the capacity for self-regulation later

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Infancy & Dependence Stage (6 months-1.5 years) Continued...

Disruptions & Trauma Patterns

- Medical complications disrupting bonding and continuity of care
- Not supported in developmental needs such as crawling, pulling up, standing and walking, being pushed to walk, etc.
- Over-rigid caregiving (scheduled feeding, limited touch) or inconsistent attunement
- Somatic presentations: collapse in chest/shoulders, lack of spinal support, rigidity in arms/legs
- Psychological imprint: helplessness, rejection, unworthiness, loss of place, not in touch with core needs, not a good connection with core self, mistrust in the world as a safety net

Core Needs & Negative Cognitions

- Core needs at this stage: Safety, Connection, Validation, basic physical needs, Play, (limited) Agency, Emotional Regulation
- Common NCs: “I am not worthy of support,” “I cannot get my needs met,” “I cannot make it on my own,” “I am not good enough,” “It is not safe to rest,” “I will be abandoned”, “It’s not okay for me to have needs,” “When I am met, it is not what I truly need,” “My rhythm is not seen and matched”

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Independence in Relationship Stage (1.5–3 years)

Developmental Needs

- Exploration and self-assertion while maintaining connection
- Autonomy without abandonment, protection without overprotection
- Embodied “No” as a foundation for agency and authenticity
- Creative exploration and becoming a scientist of the world

Disruptions & Trauma Patterns

- Shaming of needs or boundary-setting that is harsh or punitive
- Chronic power struggles, conditional love, neglect or abuse
- Overprotection (blocked autonomy) or premature independence (pushed out of dependency)
- Somatic presentations:
 - Fawning/Over-Adaptation: forward-leaning, collapsed chest, shallow breath
 - Chronic Defiance: rigid jaw, bracing shoulders, narrowed focus
 - Avoidant Independence: disconnected core, floating energy, lack of grounding
 - Collapse/Indecision: flaccid tone, unfocused eyes, low voice
 - Freeze in Choice: stillness without alertness, stiff extremities
 - Flight: excessive anxiety that is not regulated by caregiver, client stays stuck in anxious loops, high motor expressions such as running or fidgeting.

- Resource and pace sessions to prevent overwhelm

STAGES OF DEVELOPMENT

Independence in Relationship Stage (1.5–3 years) Continued...

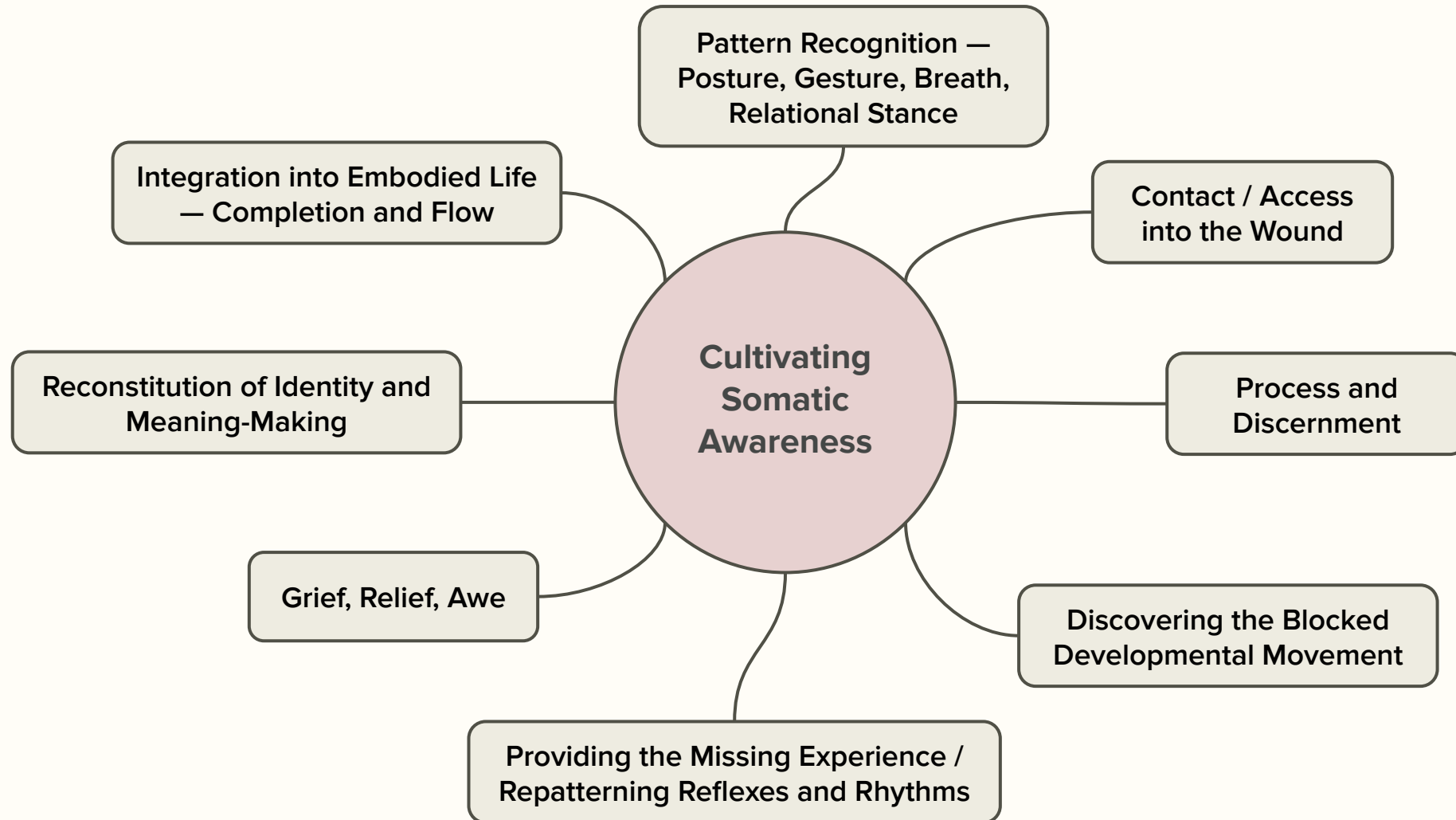
Core Needs & Negative Cognitions

- Core need: It is okay to be me, I can explore the world in safety, I can be in relation with the world and in support with my caregiver. I am powerful and independent and have preferences.
- Common NCs: “I must perform to be loved,” “It is not okay to be me,” “I cannot protect myself,” “I am unlovable”, “I am not supported in my creativity,” “I will be dominated when I exert needs,” “I can’t disagree or I lose connection with my caregiver,” “I have preferences that I have to resist to not disappear”

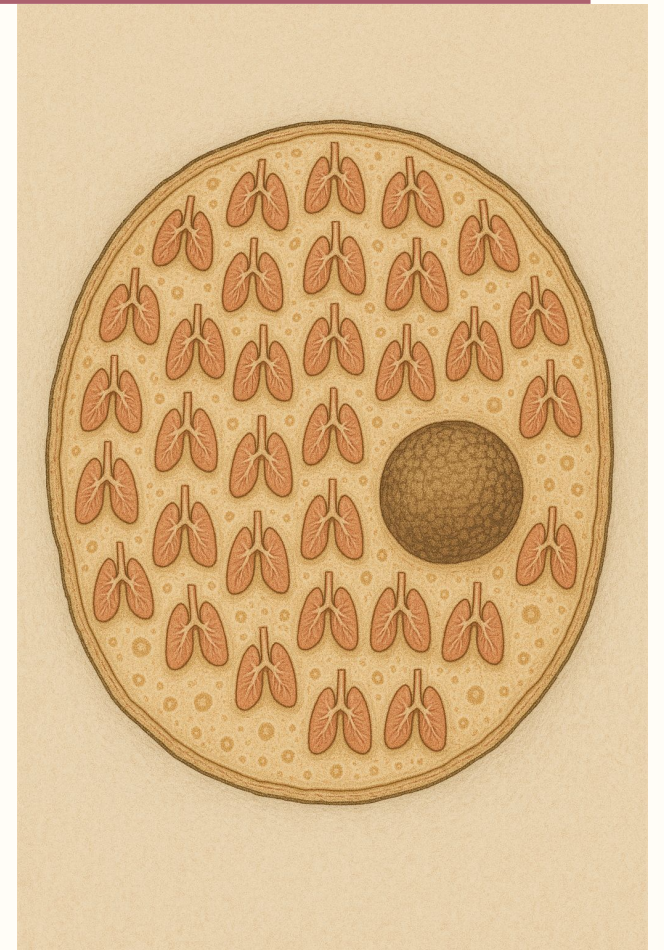
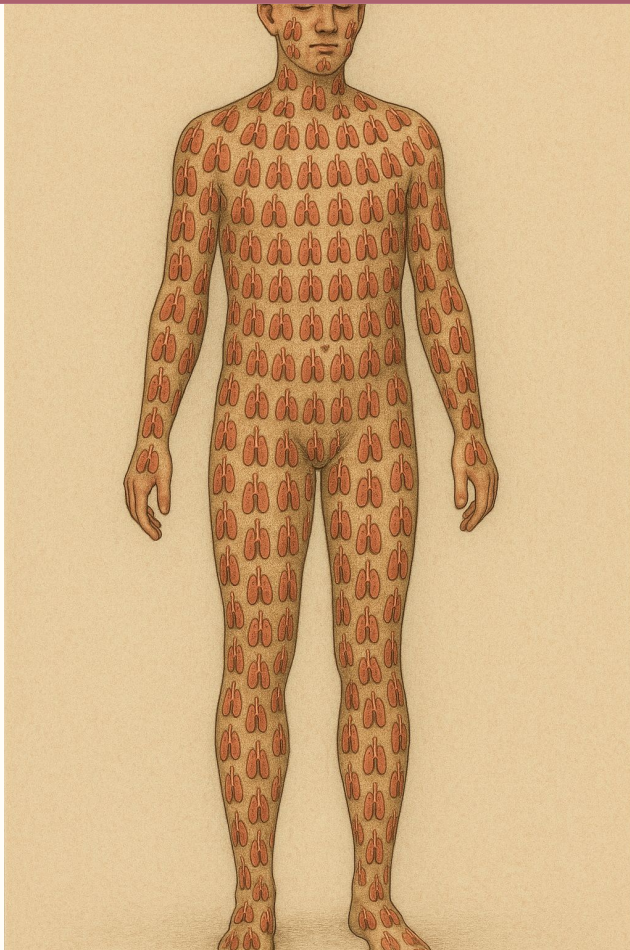
Principles of Somatic Development Trauma Therapy

- Support proceeds movement
- Resource and pace sessions to prevent overwhelm
- Therapist attends to the shifts state in the client and adjusts
 - Tone of voice
 - Pacing
 - Slowing down
 - Use simple language
 - Tracking somatic indicators (micro expressions)
 - Adjust one's gaze (soften, receptive)

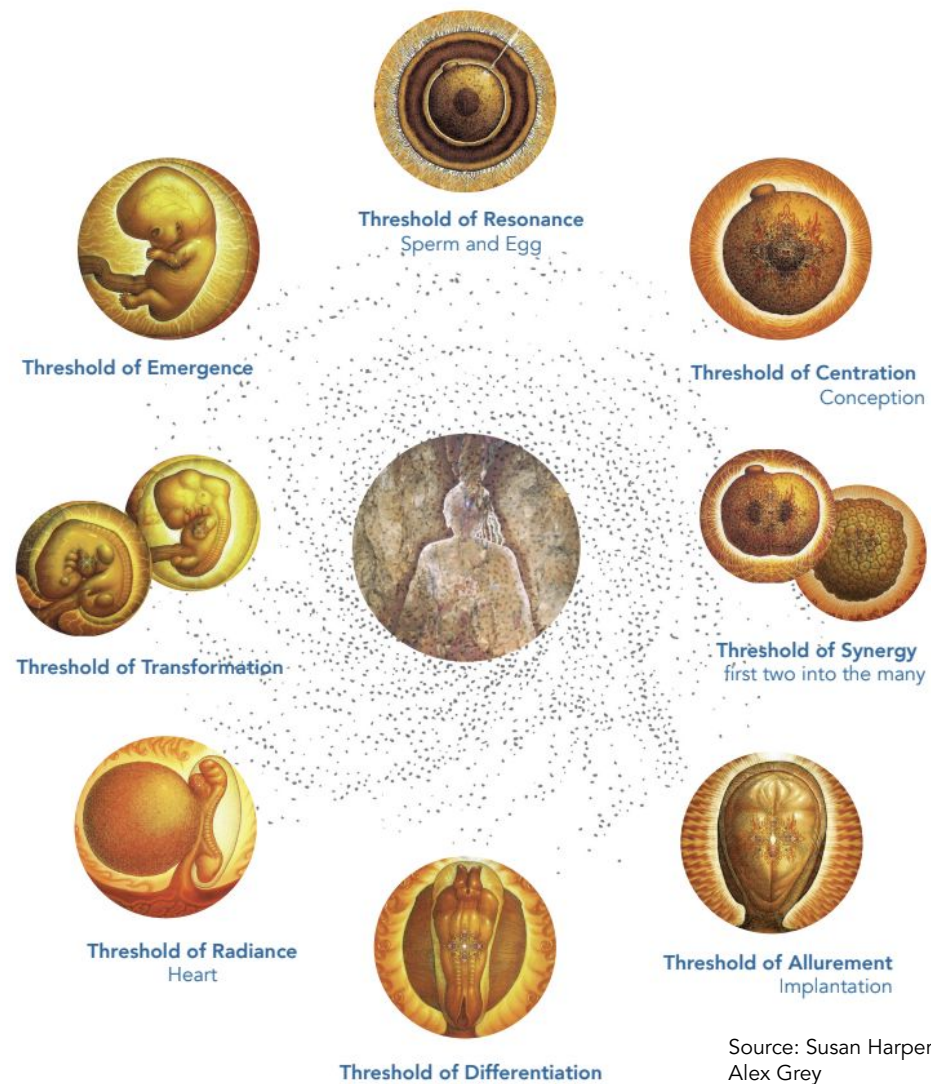
The 8-Phase Map of Developmental Repair



Cellular Breathing Exercise

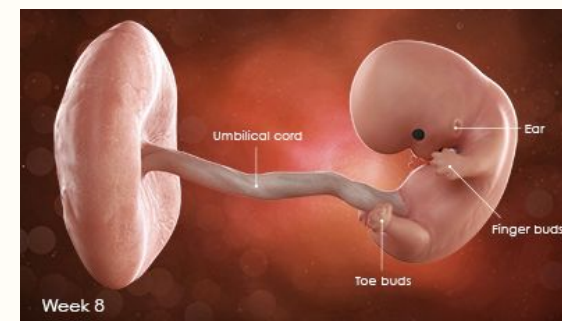


JOURNEY OF BECOMING



Source: Susan Harper, Images
Alex Grey

Navel Radiation Exercise



Starfish pattern of movement
6 limb motion
Wave like motion: center to
periphery



QUESTIONS